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NSC PRINCIPALS MEETING BRIEFING BOOK

Monday, March 16, 2026

Iran Theater Assessment & Forward Options

Houthi Reentry Calculus & Red Sea Contingency Planning

DATE: March 14, 2026 (Prepared for March 16 NSC Principals Meeting)

FROM: Chairman of the Joint Chiefs of Staff

TO: The President; The Vice President; The Secretary of State; The Secretary of Defense; The National Security Advisor; The Director of the CIA; The Attorney General; The Director of National Intelligence; The Secretary of the Treasury

SUBJECT: Iran Theater Assessment (Day 15+), Houthi Reentry Contingency, Forward Military Options, and Recommendations for Presidential Decision

REFERENCES: (A) CJCS Memo V8, March 9, 2025 (Houthi Threat — Retroactive Simulation); (B) Operation Rough Rider AAR; (C) 2025 US-Houthi Ceasefire Terms; (D) CENTCOM OPLAN 5120 (Iran Contingency)

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I. EXECUTIVE SUMMARY

Mr. President, the United States is fifteen days into the most significant military engagement since the 2003 invasion of Iraq. The February 28 joint US-Israel strike campaign against Iran killed Supreme Leader Ali Khamenei and decapitated much of the senior IRGC command structure. Iran has responded with over 500 ballistic missiles and 2,000 drones directed at US regional installations and Israel. The Strait of Hormuz is effectively closed. Gulf Cooperation Council allies are under daily attack. Oil prices have surged 40%+. Campaign costs are approaching $1.5–1.9 billion per day with no congressional appropriation.

This briefing addresses three decision requirements for Monday's NSC Principals meeting:

1. Iran Theater: Continue, escalate, or de-escalate? The Joint Chiefs assess that a managed exit — combining sustained military pressure with diplomatic reengagement via Oman — offers the highest probability of a favorable endstate while avoiding catastrophic escalation.

2. Houthi Reentry: The Houthis have not yet entered the war kinetically but are at elevated readiness. The Joint Chiefs assess a 40–50% probability of limited Red Sea attacks within 30 days, rising if the war extends. Pre-positioning for Operation Rough Rider II is recommended immediately.

3. Hormuz Reopening: Naval escort operations for commercial tankers should begin within 72 hours. Every day of Hormuz closure costs the global economy approximately $1.5–2 billion in disrupted trade. The President has publicly committed to escorts; operational delay undermines credibility.

The Joint Chiefs assess the most likely endstate (35%) is a protracted stalemate lasting 60+ days at a cost exceeding $50 billion, absent diplomatic intervention. The recommended course of action combines Hormuz escort operations, Houthi deterrence signaling, and reactivation of the Omani diplomatic channel.

II. SITUATION REPORT — IRAN THEATER (Day 15, March 14, 2026)

A. Operational Summary

On February 28, 2026, the United States and Israel launched a joint surprise attack on Iranian military, nuclear, and leadership targets. The opening salvo killed Supreme Leader Ali Khamenei, multiple family members, and an estimated 40 senior officials. Key strikes targeted the Leadership House compound, IRGC headquarters (Malek-Ashtar building), and nuclear facilities at Fordow, Natanz, and Isfahan using GBU-57 Massive Ordnance Penetrator bombs delivered by B-2A Spirit stealth bombers.

Iran responded with a massive retaliatory barrage. As of Day 15, Iranian state media reports 500+ ballistic/naval missiles and nearly 2,000 drones launched, with approximately 60% directed at U.S. regional targets and 40% at Israel. The rate of ballistic missile launches has declined, suggesting either depletion of missile/launcher stores or deliberate rationing. On March 8, Mojtaba Khamenei — son of the killed Supreme Leader — was elected as his successor. The IRGC, along with senior Iranian officials, pledged loyalty. The new Supreme Leader has vowed continued retaliation and closure of the Strait of Hormuz.

B. Theater Status Matrix

THEATER	STATUS (Day 15)	THREAT	TREND
Iran (Direct)	US struck Kharg Island military targets (90 sites). Nuclear facilities at Fordow, Natanz, Isfahan hit. DIA: enriched uranium may have been moved pre-strike.	**CRITICAL**	**ESCALATING**
Strait of Hormuz	Effectively closed. IRGC fired on 2 vessels. 16+ ships attacked since Feb 28. New Supreme Leader vowed continued closure. IRGC says ships may transit if they cooperate with Iranian navy.	**CRITICAL**	**WORSENING**
GCC States	Bahrain: 114 missiles, 190 drones intercepted. Saudi Arabia intercepting daily drone waves. Dubai Creek Harbour tower struck. Qatar missile alert. Oman: 2 killed.	**HIGH**	**ESCALATING**
Lebanon/Hezbollah	Hezbollah reactivated attacks on Israel. Lebanese govt banned Hezbollah military activity — ineffective. Israel struck Beirut, including Lebanese University campus (2 academics killed).	**HIGH**	**ESCALATING**
Yemen/Houthis	Rhetorical solidarity only. Mass rallies in Sanaa. No kinetic action as of Day 15. Abdul-Malik al-Houthi: "Hands on the trigger." Internal debate ongoing. Arsenal degraded by 2024–25 Israeli strikes.	**ELEVATED**	**WATCH**
Iraq (PMF/KH)	Militia attacks on US bases continue. KC-46 crashed in western Iraq (6 crew killed — non-hostile). Italian/French installations damaged by Iranian fire.	**HIGH**	**SUSTAINED**

III. STRATEGIC OBJECTIVES (Updated for Iran Conflict)

The Joint Chiefs have identified six principal objectives for the Iran theater, incorporating the expanded scope of operations since February 28:

1. Neutralize Iran's nuclear weapons capability: Prevent Iranian nuclear breakout. The DIA/CIA split assessment on the effectiveness of Fordow/Natanz/Isfahan strikes must be resolved. If Iran moved enriched uranium pre-strike, additional operations may be required.

2. Reopen the Strait of Hormuz: Restore commercial shipping transit. This is the single most important economic objective. Every day of closure costs approximately $1.5–2 billion in disrupted trade and accelerates a potential global recession.

3. Prevent Houthi reentry into hostilities: Deter Houthi attacks on Red Sea shipping and Israel. A dual-chokepoint closure (Hormuz + Bab el-Mandeb) would constitute an unprecedented global economic crisis.

4. Protect US forces and allied installations: Reduce vulnerability of US bases in Qatar, Bahrain, UAE, and Iraq to Iranian missile and drone attacks. The deployment of 10,000 interceptor drones is the near-term priority.

5. Manage escalation: Prevent the conflict from escalating to Rungs 8–10 on the Kahn escalation ladder (ground invasion, nuclear demonstration, nuclear exchange). The conflict has already reached Rung 7 — the fastest major-power escalation since 1991.

6. Define and achieve an endstate: The NSC has not yet defined what constitutes "victory" or under what conditions military operations cease. The Joint Chiefs assess that the absence of a defined endstate is the single greatest strategic risk.

IV. PREDICTIVE VALIDATION — V8 MEMO SCORECARD

The V8 CJCS memorandum, dated March 9, 2025, advanced six core analytical predictions. Twelve months later, and fifteen days into direct US-Iran hostilities, the Joint Chiefs assess the accuracy of each prediction against observed outcomes. See the prediction validation table below.

#	V8 PREDICTION (Mar 2025)	OBSERVED OUTCOME (Mar 2026)	STATUS	SCORE
1	Decapitation of symbolic leadership produces hardline continuity, not moderation	Khamenei killed Feb 28. Mojtaba Khamenei elected Supreme Leader Mar 8. IRGC pledged loyalty. Hardline posture deepened.	**CONFIRMED**	**HIGH**
2	Iranian proxy networks retain capability despite US air campaign	Hezbollah reactivated in Lebanon; Iraqi PMF launching attacks; Houthis at elevated readiness	**CONFIRMED**	**HIGH**
3	Conflict escalates to direct US-Iran engagement	USS Charlotte sank IRIS Dena. US struck Kharg Island, Fordow, Natanz, Isfahan. 500+ Iranian ballistic missiles fired at US targets.	**CONFIRMED**	**HIGH**
4	Oil market vulnerability becomes strategic lever	Hormuz effectively closed. Oil +40%. IEA released record 400M barrels. US gas $3.63/gal (22-month high).	**CONFIRMED**	**HIGH**
5	OPSEC failures compound operational risks	Signal chat incident confirmed. State of Union address telegraphed strike intent 4 days before Feb 28.	**CONFIRMED**	**MOD**
6	Iranian civil unrest validates internal pressure as highest-leverage covert option	Jan 2026 mass protests (largest since Islamic Revolution). Regime killed thousands. Treasury confirmed engineered dollar shortage.	**CONFIRMED**	**HIGH**

Assessment: Six of six V8 core predictions confirmed. The V8 analytical framework proved sound. The critical gap: V8 underestimated the speed and scale of escalation. The Iran Response Probability Matrix (V8 Appendix S) estimated 22–30% probability of direct ballistic missile response to IRGC-QF targeting. Actual outcome exceeded worst-case projections.

V. MILITARY OPTIONS — FORWARD PLANNING (Day 15+)

Option 1: Continue Current Operations (Status Quo Plus)

Sustain the current air and missile campaign against Iranian military targets while adding Hormuz escort operations and GCC force protection enhancements. This maintains pressure without further escalation.

Advantages: Avoids ground commitment; maintains initiative; continues degradation of Iranian military capacity; time may favor US if Iranian missile stocks deplete.

Risks: Stalemate. $1.5–1.9B/day unsustainable without Congressional funding. GCC allies absorbing daily attacks may recalculate. No defined endstate.

Force Requirements: Current posture plus Hormuz escort task force (2–3 DDGs), MEU for NEO standby, 10K interceptor drones fully deployed.

Option 2: Escalate — Oil Infrastructure & Ground Forces

Strike Iranian oil infrastructure on Kharg Island (beyond the March 13 military targets) and deploy ground forces to secure Hormuz corridor. This represents Rung 8 escalation.

Advantages: Maximum economic pressure on Iran; eliminates Iran's primary revenue source; physical control of Hormuz transit.

Risks: Iranian retaliation against Saudi/Gulf oil infrastructure (Abqaiq 2.0 scenario). Global oil crisis deepens. Ground forces in Iran trigger protracted occupation. International condemnation. Russian/Chinese intervention risk increases.

Force Requirements: 3–4 additional CSGs; 50,000–100,000 ground troops; 90–180 day deployment timeline; $100B+ supplemental appropriation.

THE JOINT CHIEFS DO NOT RECOMMEND THIS OPTION at this time. The risk-reward calculus is unfavorable absent clear evidence that current operations are failing to achieve strategic objectives.

Option 3: De-escalate — Managed Exit via Diplomacy

Reactivate the Omani diplomatic channel that was making progress on nuclear talks in February. Offer a 48–72 hour strike pause contingent on Hormuz reopening and cessation of Iranian retaliatory launches. Pursue a broader ceasefire framework.

Advantages: Ends economic damage; preserves military gains; Iran's Foreign Minister stated a "historic" agreement was "within reach" before Feb 28 strikes. Oman and Qatar remain credible intermediaries.

Risks: Perceived as weakness; Iran may use pause to reconstitute; domestic political cost; Mojtaba Khamenei may not have sufficient authority to negotiate.

Force Requirements: Maintain current posture during negotiations; diplomatic team at Deputy Secretary level or above; Omani/Qatari facilitation.

CJCS Recommendation: Combined Option 1 + Option 3

The Joint Chiefs recommend simultaneous execution of continued military operations (Option 1) with diplomatic engagement (Option 3). Specifically: (a) begin Hormuz escort operations within 72 hours; (b) deploy interceptor drones to GCC bases; (c) pre-position for Operation Rough Rider II (Houthi contingency); (d) reactivate the Omani channel at the Deputy Secretary level; (e) formally notify Congress under the War Powers Resolution.

VI. WEAPONS SYSTEMS & CAMPAIGN COST ANALYSIS

The following weapons systems constitute the primary US military assets deployed in the Iran theater. Unit costs are unclassified FY2026 estimates. See Appendices D–F for visual cost comparisons and platform specification cards.

A. Offensive Strike Assets

GBU-57 Massive Ordnance Penetrator: 30,000 lb bunker buster. Only deliverable by B-2A Spirit. Penetrates 200+ ft of earth/60 ft of reinforced concrete. Used against Fordow, Natanz, Isfahan underground nuclear facilities. Unit cost: ~$3.5M.

BGM-109 Tomahawk (TLAM): Range 1,550 mi. GPS/INS + TERCOM + DSMAC terminal guidance. Launched from DDG-51 Mk-41 VLS (90 cells/ship) and SSNs. Primary standoff weapon for Iranian military infrastructure. Unit cost: ~$2.5M.

F/A-18E/F Super Hornet: Carrier strike fighter. JDAM ($25K–$40K), SDB (GBU-39, ~$40K), HARM anti-radiation. Carrier-based from CVN-78 and CVN-72. Unit cost: ~$70.5M.

B-2A Spirit: Strategic stealth bomber. GBU-57 delivery platform. Unrefueled range 6,000 nmi. VLO (RCS estimated at less than 0.1 sq m). Only 19 operational airframes. Unit cost: ~$2.1B.

B-52H Stratofortress: Standoff cruise missile carrier. JASSM-ER, CALCM. 16,000+ nmi range with refueling. Sorties from Diego Garcia and CONUS. Unit cost: ~$84M (1962 dollars; replacement cost significantly higher).

B. Defensive Assets

SM-6 / RIM-174 ERAM: Extended range active missile. 130+ nmi range. Dual-purpose: BMD + anti-ship. Primary Hormuz escort defensive weapon. Unit cost: ~$4.3M.

Interceptor Drones (CUAS): 10,000 deploying to Gulf bases. Counter-UAS mission against Iranian Shahed-type drones. Inverts the cost asymmetry: $150K interceptor vs $50K threat = 3:1 cost advantage (vs. 86:1 disadvantage with SM-6). This is a doctrinal shift.

Phalanx CIWS: 20mm Gatling gun. 4,500 rds/min final-layer defense. ~$11.5M/installation.

MIM-104 Patriot PAC-3: Terminal ballistic missile defense. Deployed to GCC installations. Unit cost: ~$4M per interceptor.

C. Campaign Cost Assessment

METRIC	FIGURE	CONTEXT
First 6 days total	**$11.3 billion**	Per 250+ organization coalition letter to Congress
Estimated daily burn rate	**$1.5–$1.9 billion/day**	Declining as initial surge subsides; still substantial
Projected 30-day cost	**$30–40 billion**	Requires emergency supplemental appropriation
Congressional status	**No appropriation**	First public oversight hearing planned but not scheduled
Cost asymmetry (defense)	**SM-6 ($4.3M) vs drone ($50K)**	86:1 disadvantage — interceptor drones reduce to 3:1

VII. HOUTHI REENTRY CALCULUS — DECISION ANALYSIS

The Houthi decision on whether to enter the Iran war is the single most consequential variable for Red Sea planning. As of Day 15, the Houthis have confined their response to rhetorical solidarity and mass mobilization but have not launched kinetic attacks.

A. Factors Favoring Restraint

Israeli decapitation trauma: Between August and September 2025, Israel killed the Houthi prime minister, a dozen cabinet members, and their chief of staff. The head of the missile/drone unit (Zakaria Hajar) was also killed. This institutional memory powerfully deters provocation.

Arsenal degradation: CENTCOM seized 750+ tons of Iranian materiel in July 2025. A Century International study found 80%+ of seized items were manufacturing inputs (seekers, guidance electronics), not finished weapons. Critical bottleneck components require imports that are now further disrupted.

Saudi détente at risk: The de facto truce with Riyadh since 2022 is the Houthis' most valuable diplomatic asset. Red Sea attacks risk unifying the fractured Yemeni coalition against them.

Threat-as-strategy: Restraint-with-threat generates strategic value without expenditure: shipping insurance premiums remain elevated, Saudi planning must account for a southern front, and 300,000+ mobilized fighters remain positioned for domestic opportunities.

May 2025 ceasefire gains: Trump halted anti-Houthi strikes in May 2025. Resuming attacks forfeits this de-escalation gain.

B. Factors Favoring Reentry

Ideological imperative: Abdul-Malik al-Houthi has explicitly stated "hands are on the trigger." Failure to act risks credibility.

Iranian activation request: Mojtaba Khamenei publicly thanked the Houthis. Analysts assess entry is "only a matter of time" if Tehran formally requests it.

Dual-chokepoint leverage: With Hormuz closed, Houthi attacks on the Bab el-Mandeb would close both major oil routes simultaneously — the most powerful economic weapon available to the Axis of Resistance.

Expanded naval capabilities: Houthi naval assets include Toufan explosive boats, unmanned submersibles, naval mines, and mobile launchers hidden in tunnels across northern and western Yemen.

C. Probability Assessment

SCENARIO	PROB	TRIGGER CONDITIONS
Full kinetic reentry (Red Sea + Israel)	**30–40%**	Formal IRGC activation; Israeli strike on Yemen; Saudi détente collapse
Limited Red Sea attacks (shipping only)	**40–50%**	War extends past Day 30; IRGC signals importance of Bab el-Mandeb
Continued restraint (rhetorical)	15–25%	Rapid ceasefire; Houthis secure Saudi concessions; IRGC tells Houthis to hold
Strategic realignment (abandon Iran)	5–10%	Comprehensive Saudi peace deal; regime survival overrides ideology

VIII. COVERT & CLANDESTINE OPTIONS (Updated)

The January 2026 mass protests in Iran — and Treasury Secretary Bessent's confirmation that Washington engineered the dollar shortage that triggered them — validated the V8 memo's assessment that internal pressure is the highest-leverage covert option. The following covert tracks should be maintained or activated:

Option A — Economic Pressure (Ongoing): Continue and intensify the dollar shortage campaign. With Iran's oil exports now physically disrupted by the conflict, the economic pressure multiplier is unprecedented. Coordinate with OFAC to target any remaining Iranian financial networks.

Option B — Cyber Operations: CYBERCOM offensive operations against Iranian military C2, missile fire control, and drone navigation. The declining rate of Iranian ballistic missile launches may already reflect successful cyber interference.

Option C — Information Operations: Exploit the Mojtaba Khamenei succession to amplify regime illegitimacy. The new Supreme Leader was selected by a rump Assembly of Experts (Israel destroyed the meeting building, delaying the vote). IO campaigns highlighting dynastic succession undermine the Islamic Republic's revolutionary legitimacy.

Option D — Proxy/Tribal Disruption in Yemen: If the Houthis enter the war, activate Saudi GIP and UAE SSS channels for internal disruption. Financial/logistical support to tribal leaders in Sa'dah Governorate who resent Houthi domination. This replicates the V8 Option D framework.

Option E — Support Iranian Domestic Opposition: The January 2026 protest movement demonstrated that regime legitimacy is at its lowest point since the Islamic Revolution. Covert support to protest networks, independent media, and civil society — through cut-outs to maintain deniability — maintains internal pressure that complements military operations.

IX. ECONOMIC IMPACT — DUAL CHOKEPOINT SCENARIO

The 2026 Iran conflict has created economic disruption exceeding all V8 modeling. The effective closure of the Strait of Hormuz — through which one-fifth of global petroleum liquids transit — constitutes a strategic-level economic weapon.

METRIC	PRE-WAR	CURRENT (Day 15)
Brent Crude Oil	~$75/barrel	**~$105+/barrel (+40%)**
US Gas Price	~$3.15/gallon	**$3.63/gallon (22-month high)**
Hormuz Transit	~21M bbl/day	**Effectively closed**
IEA Emergency Release	N/A	**400M barrels (record)**
Ships Attacked (Gulf)	0	**16+ since Feb 28**
F1 Races Cancelled	N/A	Bahrain & Saudi Arabia (Apr)

Dual-chokepoint scenario: If Houthis simultaneously close the Bab el-Mandeb, the world's two most critical maritime energy chokepoints would be under hostile interdiction simultaneously for the first time in modern history. Saudi Arabia is currently relying on Red Sea facilities to maintain oil exports to Asia. Houthi interdiction would eliminate Saudi Arabia's primary remaining export pathway. See Appendix B for the dual-chokepoint map.

X. CASUALTY ASSESSMENT & LOAC REVIEW

CATEGORY	REPORTED FIGURES	SOURCE / CAVEAT
Iranian Civilian Deaths	1,444 killed; 18,551 injured (Day 14)	Iran Health Ministry; independent verification limited
Iranian Military Deaths	4,000+ (Hengaw, Day 10)	Kurdish HR org; includes IRGC and Artesh
Iranian Officials Killed	~40 on Feb 28 alone	CBS sources; includes Khamenei and family
US Military Deaths	6 (KC-46 crash, Iraq)	Non-hostile crash; no combat deaths confirmed
GCC Casualties	2 killed in Oman; injuries across Gulf	Multiple GCC states under daily attack
Civilian Sites Struck (Iran)	6,668+ per Red Crescent	Includes schools, IRIB HQ, parliament

LOAC concerns requiring JAG review: (1) Reports of double-tap strikes maximizing casualties; (2) Sinking of the unarmed IRIS Dena during a multinational exercise — the ship carried no ammunition; (3) Minab school incident (180 reported killed, mostly children); (4) SECDEF Hegseth's statement that US forces will show "no quarter, no mercy" — "no quarter" is explicitly prohibited under the Geneva Conventions. The Joint Chiefs will not execute unlawful orders regardless of political direction.

XI. FORWARD PREDICTIONS (30 / 60 / 90 Day)

A. 30-Day Horizon (March 14 – April 13, 2026)

PREDICTED DEVELOPMENT	PROB	CONF
Houthi resumption of Red Sea shipping attacks	**55–70%**	MODERATE
Iranian missile stockpile forces shift to asymmetric warfare	**65–80%**	MOD-HIGH
US naval escort ops begin through Hormuz	**70–85%**	HIGH
Congressional oversight hearings begin	**80–90%**	HIGH
Oil prices exceed $120/barrel	**40–55%**	MODERATE

B. 60-Day Horizon (March 14 – May 13, 2026)

PREDICTED DEVELOPMENT	PROB	CONF
Ceasefire negotiations begin via Oman/Qatar	**50–65%**	MODERATE
Mojtaba Khamenei consolidates power; IRGC fractures surface	**45–60%**	MODERATE
US ground forces deploy to Hormuz corridor	**20–35%**	LOW-MOD
Global recession triggered by energy disruption	**25–40%**	LOW-MOD

C. 90-Day Horizon (March 14 – June 12, 2026)

PREDICTED DEVELOPMENT	PROB	CONF
Iranian nuclear program reconstitution begins (dispersed)	**70–85%**	MOD-HIGH
Formal ceasefire agreement (limited scope)	**35–50%**	MODERATE
Iranian regime survives under Mojtaba	**60–75%**	MODERATE
US domestic political crisis over war costs	**55–70%**	MOD-HIGH

XII. NSC DECISION FRAMEWORK — MONDAY AGENDA

The Joint Chiefs recommend the following decision sequence for Monday's NSC Principals meeting. See Appendix J for the full decision tree.

Decision 1: Hormuz Escort Operations (Immediate)

Authorize US naval escorts for commercial tankers through the Strait of Hormuz within 72 hours. The President has publicly committed to this; delay undermines credibility. ROE: engage any platform that targets escorted shipping. Estimated cost: $150–200M/month.

Decision 2: Houthi Deterrence (Immediate)

Authorize pre-positioning for Operation Rough Rider II. Communicate through the Omani channel that Houthi reentry will trigger immediate, overwhelming strikes. Do not wait for the Houthis to act.

Decision 3: Diplomatic Track (Within 72 hours)

Authorize Deputy Secretary of State to open contact with Omani intermediaries for a ceasefire framework. Minimum framework: Hormuz reopening + cessation of retaliatory launches + nuclear inspections regime.

Decision 4: Congressional Notification (Immediate)

Submit formal War Powers Resolution notification. Proactively engage Congressional leadership on emergency supplemental appropriation ($30–40B for 30 days).

Decision 5: Endstate Definition (Discussion Required)

The NSC must answer: What does "victory" look like? Under what conditions do strikes cease? What is the post-war architecture? The Joint Chiefs cannot plan an exit strategy without guidance on what the exit looks like.

XIII. U.S. FORCE POSTURE — CURRENT DEPLOYMENTS (Day 15)

The following table summarizes current US military deployments in the Iran theater. Force posture reflects the largest American military buildup in the Middle East since Operation Iraqi Freedom (2003).

ASSET	LOCATION	MISSION	STATUS
USS Abraham Lincoln CSG	Persian Gulf / Arabian Sea	Strike; Hormuz escort	**ON STATION**
USS Gerald R. Ford CSG	Eastern Med / Gulf transit	Strike; ISR; Force Protection	**ON STATION**
USS Charlotte (SSN-766)	Indian Ocean	Subsurface strike / interdiction	**ACTIVE**
MEU (~2,200 Marines)	Deploying from Okinawa	Amphibious ops; NEO standby	**EN ROUTE**
USS Tripoli + 2,500 Marines	SECDEF-approved deployment	Amphibious assault capability	**APPROVED**
10,000 Interceptor Drones	Multiple Gulf installations	CUAS / Force Protection	**DEPLOYING**
B-2A Spirit (multiple)	Diego Garcia / CONUS	Strategic strike (GBU-57 MOP)	**ONGOING OPS**
B-52H Stratofortress (multiple)	Diego Garcia / Al Udeid	Standoff cruise missile	**ONGOING OPS**
MQ-9 Reaper (multiple)	Regional bases (classified)	ISR / Persistent surveillance	**CONTINUOUS**
Patriot PAC-3 batteries	Al Udeid, Al Dhafra, Bahrain	Terminal BMD	**ACTIVE**

Force posture assessment: The deployment of 10,000 interceptor drones represents a doctrinal shift from the cost-asymmetry problem identified in V8 (SM-6 at $4.3M vs. Iranian drone at $50K). Drone-on-drone defense inverts the cost equation to a 3:1 advantage. However, this capability is still deploying and not yet fully operational. The Marine deployments (MEU from Okinawa + USS Tripoli) signal preparation for both non-combatant evacuation operations (NEO) and potential amphibious action, though ground deployment into Iran is not recommended at this time.

The USS Charlotte's sinking of the IRIS Dena represents the first submarine kill of an enemy warship since the Falklands War (1982) and the first by a US submarine since World War II. This action demonstrates US undersea dominance but raises significant proportionality questions given the Dena was reportedly unarmed and returning from a multinational exercise. The incident has been condemned by multiple nations including India (which hosted the exercise) and Sri Lanka (which conducted rescue operations).

XIV. OPERATIONAL TIMELINE — HORMUZ ESCORT OPERATIONS

If the NSC approves Hormuz escort operations on Monday, the following phased timeline governs execution:

Phase I: Initiation (Days 1–7 from approval)

Day 1–2: CENTCOM issues FRAGO to CTF-59 (Combined Maritime Forces). USS Abraham Lincoln CSG assumes escort corridor anchor position. 2–3 DDG-51s detach for screening duties. ROE briefed to all escort commanders.

Day 3–5: First commercial tanker convoy forms at Fujairah anchorage (UAE). DDG screening formation established at 5–10 nmi ahead. MQ-9 Reaper provides persistent overhead ISR. P-8A Poseidon maritime patrol. First transit of Hormuz under escort.

Day 5–7: Establish sustainable convoy cycle: 2–3 convoys per week. Each convoy: 5–10 tankers with 2 DDG escorts + 1 SSN subsurface screen. MH-60R helo ASW support. Estimated throughput: 3–5M bbl/day (vs. pre-war 21M bbl/day — partial reopening).

Phase II: Sustained Operations (Days 7–30)

Force protection: Deploy mine countermeasures vessels (MCM) to clear Iranian naval mines in the Hormuz corridor. Avenger-class MCM and unmanned mine hunting systems. Iranian mine threat is assessed as HIGH — Houthi-style naval mines have been observed in IRGC inventory.

Escalation management: Iranian IRGC Navy fast attack craft (FAC) and midget submarines remain the primary threat to escort convoys. SM-6 and Phalanx CIWS provide layered defense. ROE must be calibrated: engage confirmed hostile fire but avoid incidents with Iranian vessels conducting routine navigation.

Throughput scaling: As mine clearance progresses, expand convoy size and frequency. Target: 8–12M bbl/day by Day 30 (40–60% of pre-war levels). Full reopening requires either Iranian cooperation or defeat of IRGC naval capability.

Phase III: Transition (Days 30–60)

If ceasefire achieved: Transition to multinational maritime monitoring force. Invite GCC navies, UK Royal Navy, and willing coalition partners. Reduce US escort commitment to advisory/backstop role.

If conflict continues: Expand escort operations to permanent task force. Request NATO maritime contribution. Establish permanent mine-free corridor with underwater sensor network. Estimated sustained cost: $500M–$1B/month.

XV. OPSEC & NSC PROCESS INTEGRITY

The V8 memo (Appendix V) documented the March 2025 Signal group chat incident in which NSC Principals coordinated strike planning over a commercial messaging application. The Joint Chiefs include this updated section because OPSEC failures have continued into the current conflict and directly undermine operational security.

A. State of the Union Address (February 24, 2026)

During the State of the Union Address on February 24, the President accused Iran of reviving nuclear weapons efforts and advanced missile capabilities, and warned that the US was "prepared to act if necessary." This public statement occurred four days before the February 28 strikes. American intelligence reports subsequently indicated that alleged threats of long-range Iranian ballistic missiles were unfounded, with such capabilities requiring development until approximately 2035. The President's speech effectively telegraphed strike intent, potentially allowing Iran to disperse assets — which the DIA's low-confidence assessment suggests may have occurred with enriched uranium stocks.

B. Open-Source Intelligence Exposure

The deployment of USS Gerald R. Ford was announced publicly on February 13. The USS Abraham Lincoln deployment and associated "armada" language was announced January 23. Combined with the State of the Union rhetoric, the Iranian government had approximately five weeks of advance warning that a major military operation was being prepared. This contrasts unfavorably with the 1991 Gulf War, where operational surprise was maintained despite similar force buildups, through active deception operations.

C. SECDEF Public Statements

Secretary of Defense Hegseth's statement that US forces would show "no quarter, no mercy" has been flagged by Congressional members (Rep. Vindman) as potentially constituting illegal orders under the Geneva Conventions. Article 40 of Additional Protocol I explicitly prohibits ordering that there be no survivors. While the Joint Chiefs interpret the statement as rhetoric rather than an operational directive, it creates legal exposure and damages US credibility in proportionality debates. The Joint Chiefs recommend a formal clarification from the Secretary of Defense.

D. Recommendations

1. All classified NSC discussion of this conflict must occur on JWICS (TS/SCI) or SIPRNet (SECRET) exclusively. The March 2025 Signal chat failure must not be repeated.

2. Future operational surprises require active deception operations, not public telegraphing. The State of the Union disclosure was a strategic error.

3. SECDEF rhetoric must be formally clarified as consistent with LOAC and the Geneva Conventions.

4. The NSCS Security Officer should conduct a comprehensive review of all classified communications protocols and personal device usage by Principals.

XVI. HORMUZ ESCORT OPERATIONS — COST BREAKDOWN

The following table provides a detailed cost breakdown for the recommended Hormuz escort operation (Phase I through Phase III). Costs are estimated based on historical operating tempo data from Operation Earnest Will (1987–88 Persian Gulf tanker escort) and adjusted for FY2026 platform and munition costs.

LINE ITEM	MONTHLY COST	30-DAY TOTAL	90-DAY TOTAL
DDG-51 escort operations (3 ships)	$45M	$45M	$135M
CSG on-station support (1 CVN + air wing)	$85M	$85M	$255M
SSN subsurface screening (1–2 boats)	$30M	$30M	$90M
Mine countermeasures (MCM det + UUV)	$25M	$25M	$75M
MQ-9 / P-8A ISR overwatch (continuous)	$20M	$20M	$60M
MH-60R ASW helicopter support	$8M	$8M	$24M
SM-6 / SM-2 munition replenishment (est.)	$60M	$60M	$180M
Fuel, logistics, crew support	$35M	$35M	$105M
Interceptor drone CUAS coverage (Hormuz)	$15M	$15M	$45M
TOTAL (Hormuz escort only)	**~$323M/mo**	**~$323M**	**~$969M**

Context: The Hormuz escort operation represents approximately 1–2% of the total daily campaign cost ($1.5–1.9B/day). It is the single highest-value investment available because Hormuz reopening directly addresses the global economic disruption driving domestic political pressure. For comparison, Operation Earnest Will (1987–88) cost approximately $2.1 billion in FY2026-adjusted dollars over its full duration and successfully escorted 259 convoys with one frigate damaged (USS Samuel B. Roberts, mine strike) and one frigate struck by Iranian missile (USS Stark — pre-war incident). The current Iranian threat environment is significantly more complex due to ballistic missile, drone, mine, and fast-attack craft capabilities operating simultaneously.

Historical note: Operation Praying Mantis (April 18, 1988) — the largest US naval engagement since World War II prior to the current conflict — was triggered by the USS Samuel B. Roberts mine strike during Earnest Will. The US destroyed two Iranian oil platforms, one frigate, one gunboat, and damaged a second frigate in a single day. The current conflict has already far exceeded Praying Mantis in scope, with the USS Charlotte's sinking of the IRIS Dena representing a qualitatively different level of naval engagement.

XVII. HOUTHI NAVAL THREAT ASSESSMENT — UPDATED CAPABILITIES

If the Houthis enter the war and resume Red Sea operations, their naval capabilities have expanded significantly since the 2023–2024 Red Sea crisis. The following assessment is drawn from ACLED, Century International, FDD Long War Journal, and CENTCOM interdiction records.

A. Anti-Ship Missile Systems

Ballistic: Modified Burkan-2 and Toufan ASBM variants with terminal guidance. Range: 200–400 km. These systems struck commercial vessels during the 2023–24 campaign and remain the Houthis' highest-impact weapon. Guidance systems rely on Iranian-supplied seekers — a critical supply bottleneck identified in the Century International study.

Cruise: Quds-type land-attack cruise missiles adapted for anti-ship use. Subsonic, terrain-following over water. Difficult to detect at low altitude. Range: 500–1,000 km.

Coastal defense: C-802 variants (Iranian-supplied). Anti-ship cruise missile. Range: ~120 km. Previously fired at US Navy vessels during the 2016 USS Mason incident.

B. Unmanned Systems

Aerial drones: Shahed-136 derivatives (Wahed-1/Sammad-type). One-way attack (OWA). Range: 1,500+ km. Cost: $20K–50K. Primary asymmetric weapon. UN experts counted 101 ballistic missiles fired at Israel between September 2024 and July 2025, of which 38 failed outright.

Maritime drones: Toufan explosive unmanned surface vessel (USV). High-speed remotely controlled craft designed to strike ships. Effective against stationary or slow-moving vessels. Sank multiple commercial ships during the 2023–24 campaign.

Unmanned submersibles: Newly developed unmanned underwater vehicles (UUV) capable of attacking vessels from below to evade surface detection. This is a capability that did not exist during the 2023–24 campaign and represents a qualitative escalation in Houthi naval warfare.

C. Naval Mines

Mine inventory: Multiple types of naval mines planted in or available for deployment in shipping lanes. Iranian-supplied contact mines, influence mines, and possibly smart mines with acoustic/magnetic fuzing. The mine threat is the most difficult to counter and was the primary driver of tanker damage during the Iran-Iraq Tanker War (1984–88).

Mine countermeasures gap: US mine countermeasures capability has atrophied since the 1990s. The Avenger-class MCM ships are aging (commissioned 1987–94). Unmanned mine hunting systems are still in development/limited deployment. A mine-intensive Houthi campaign would stress US MCM capacity.

D. Ground Force / Territorial

Personnel: 300,000+ recruits plus armed tribal fighters. Largest ground force in the Houthi arsenal. Primarily relevant for internal Yemeni dynamics — could exploit any vacuum in Marib, Aden, or Shabwa if anti-Houthi forces redeploy.

Tunnel/cave network: Mobile launch platforms hidden within extensive tunnel and cave systems in northern and western Yemen. These survived the 2024–25 Israeli and US strike campaigns and provide survivable launch infrastructure.

Key vulnerability: Supply chain. CENTCOM seized 750+ tons of Iranian materiel in a single July 2025 interdiction. More than 80% of items seized were manufacturing inputs (seekers, guidance electronics, engines). The Houthi domestic assembly pipeline is functional but critically dependent on imported bottleneck components — which the current Iran conflict further disrupts.

Net assessment: The Houthis retain the capability to cause significant disruption to Red Sea shipping, but their arsenal is degraded compared to the 2023–24 peak. The Israeli decapitation of senior military leadership (including the missile/drone unit chief) and the disruption of Iranian supply chains reduce both the volume and sophistication of potential attacks. However, even a reduced Houthi campaign — combining anti-ship missiles, explosive USVs, and naval mines — would be sufficient to effectively close the Bab el-Mandeb to unescorted commercial shipping, creating the dual-chokepoint scenario.

XVIII. RECOMMENDATIONS

The Joint Chiefs recommend the following course of action for the NSC Principals' approval:

1. APPROVE: Hormuz escort operations (Task Force 59+, DDG escort corridor, 72-hour initiation).

2. APPROVE: Houthi deterrence pre-positioning (CENTCOM OPLAN Rough Rider II standby).

3. APPROVE: GCC force protection surge (10,000 interceptor drones, full deployment within 14 days).

4. APPROVE: Omani diplomatic channel reactivation (Deputy Secretary level).

5. APPROVE: Congressional War Powers notification and supplemental appropriation request.

6. APPROVE: Unified DIA/CIA nuclear strike assessment (30-day deadline).

7. DO NOT APPROVE: Kharg oil infrastructure strikes at this time.

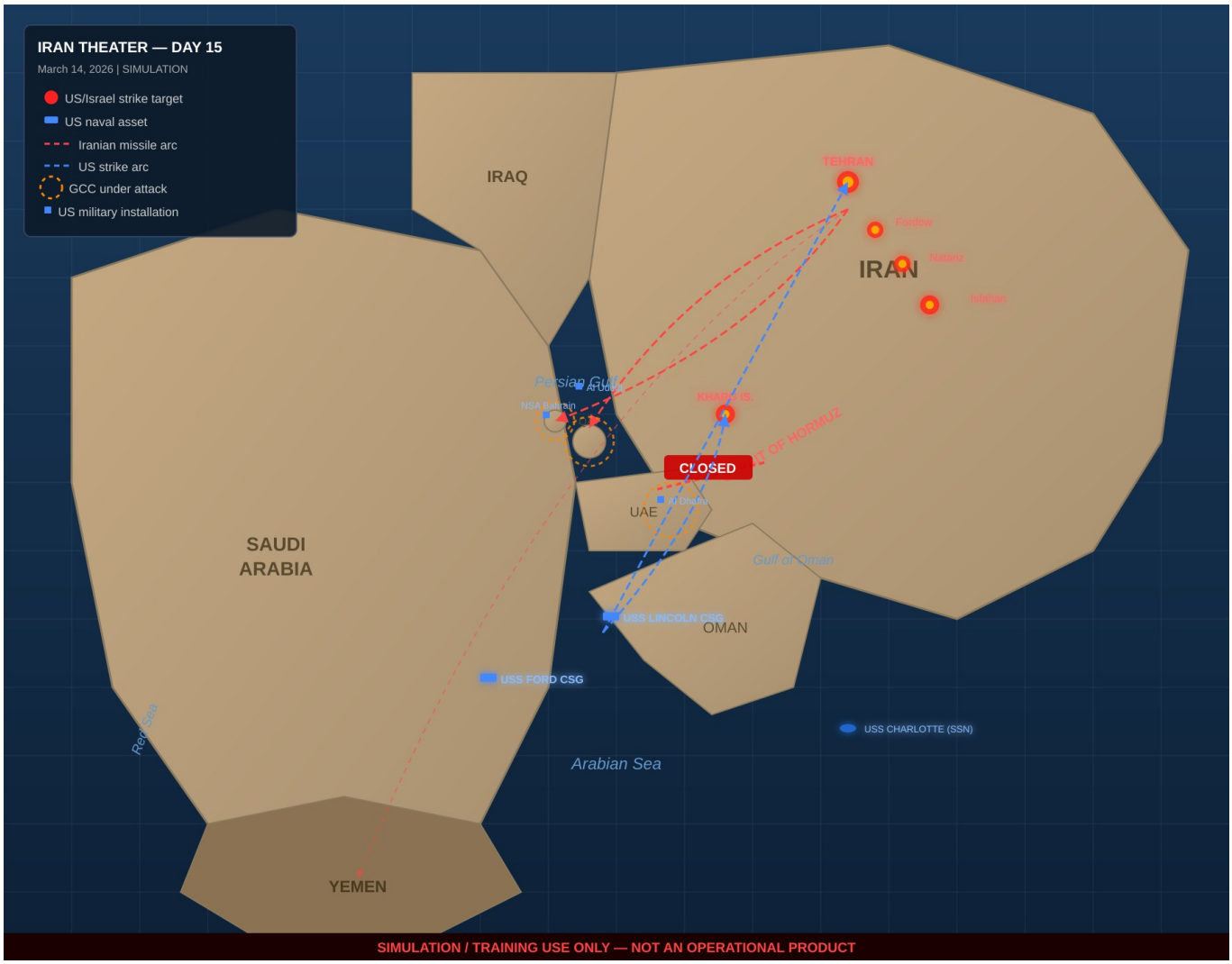
8. DO NOT APPROVE: Ground forces deployment into Iran at this time.

9. DIRECT: NSC to define endstate conditions for cessation of hostilities.

10. DIRECT: JAG review of LOAC compliance, including double-tap allegations, IRIS Dena sinking, and SECDEF rhetoric.

Submitted by:
Chairman of the Joint Chiefs of Staff
The Pentagon, Washington, D.C.

Appendix A: Iran Theater Map — Current Strike Positions & Naval Assets



US/Israel strike targets, naval assets, Iranian missile arcs, and GCC installations under attack. Ship positions illustrative.

Key geographic notes: The Persian Gulf theater encompasses approximately 600,000 square miles of maritime space. US carrier strike groups operate from the Arabian Sea (south of the Strait of Hormuz) with strike aircraft range covering all of Iran's western military infrastructure. The B-2A Spirit operates from Diego Garcia (approximately 2,500 nmi south) and CONUS bases with aerial refueling. Iranian retaliatory missile arcs cover all GCC capitals within a 1,200 km radius of western Iran.

Operational note: The USS Charlotte's position in the Indian Ocean reflects the expansion of the conflict zone beyond the Persian Gulf proper. The sinking of the IRIS Dena approximately 40 nautical miles south of Sri Lanka demonstrates that the war has global maritime dimensions, not merely regional ones.

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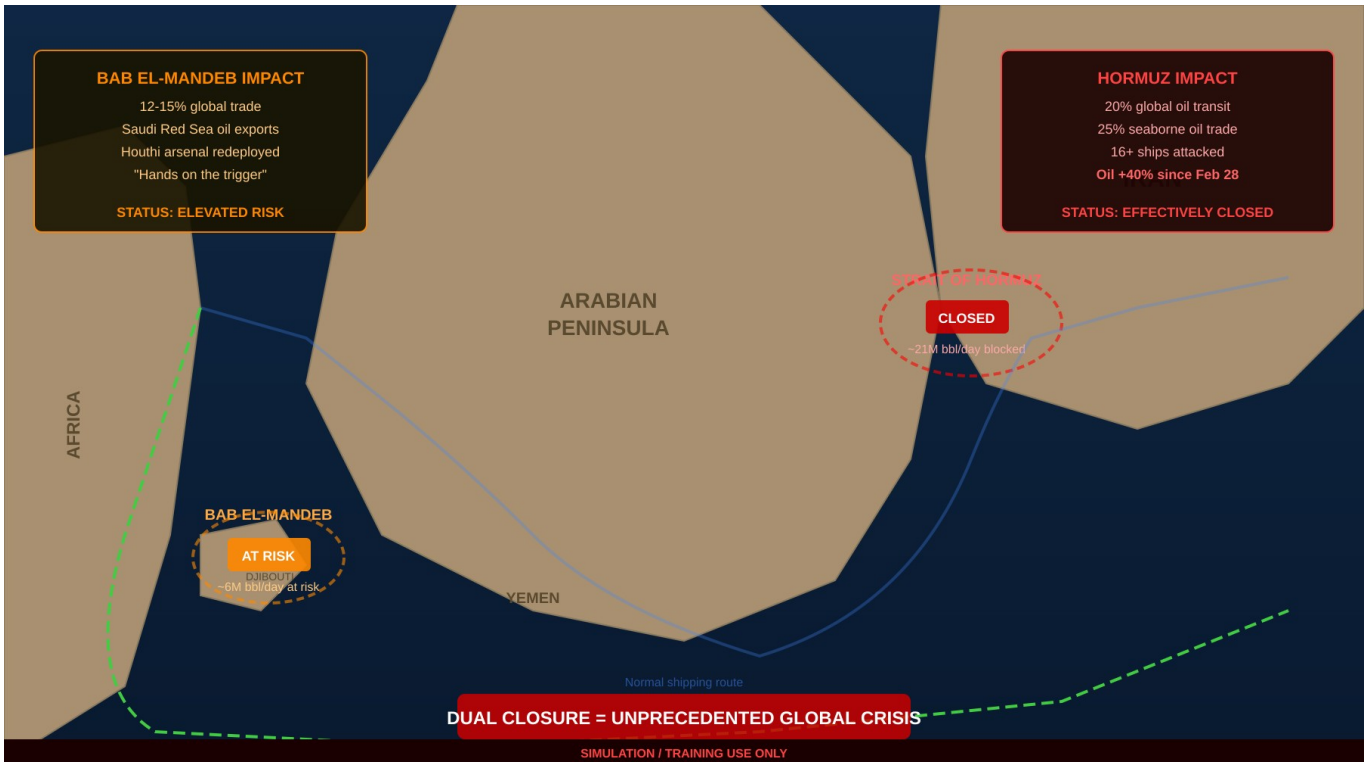
Appendix B: Dual Chokepoint Map — Strait of Hormuz & Bab el-Mandeb



Hormuz effectively closed. Bab el-Mandeb at elevated risk if Houthis enter war. Cape of Good Hope reroute adds 2-4 weeks.

Dual-chokepoint analysis: If both the Strait of Hormuz and the Bab el-Mandeb are closed simultaneously, approximately 25–30% of global seaborne oil trade would need to reroute around the Cape of Good Hope. Saudi Arabia's only remaining export pathway would be cross-peninsula pipelines to the Red Sea — which themselves would be at risk from Houthi attacks. The IEA's record release of 400 million barrels provides approximately 60–90 days of buffer at current consumption rates. Beyond that, strategic petroleum reserves would be insufficient to prevent a supply crisis.

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Appendix C: Conflict Timeline — February 28 to March 14, 2026

Key events color-coded by type: Red = US/Israel strike; Orange = Iranian response; Blue = Economic; Green = Proxy/Houthi; Gold = Escalation milestone.

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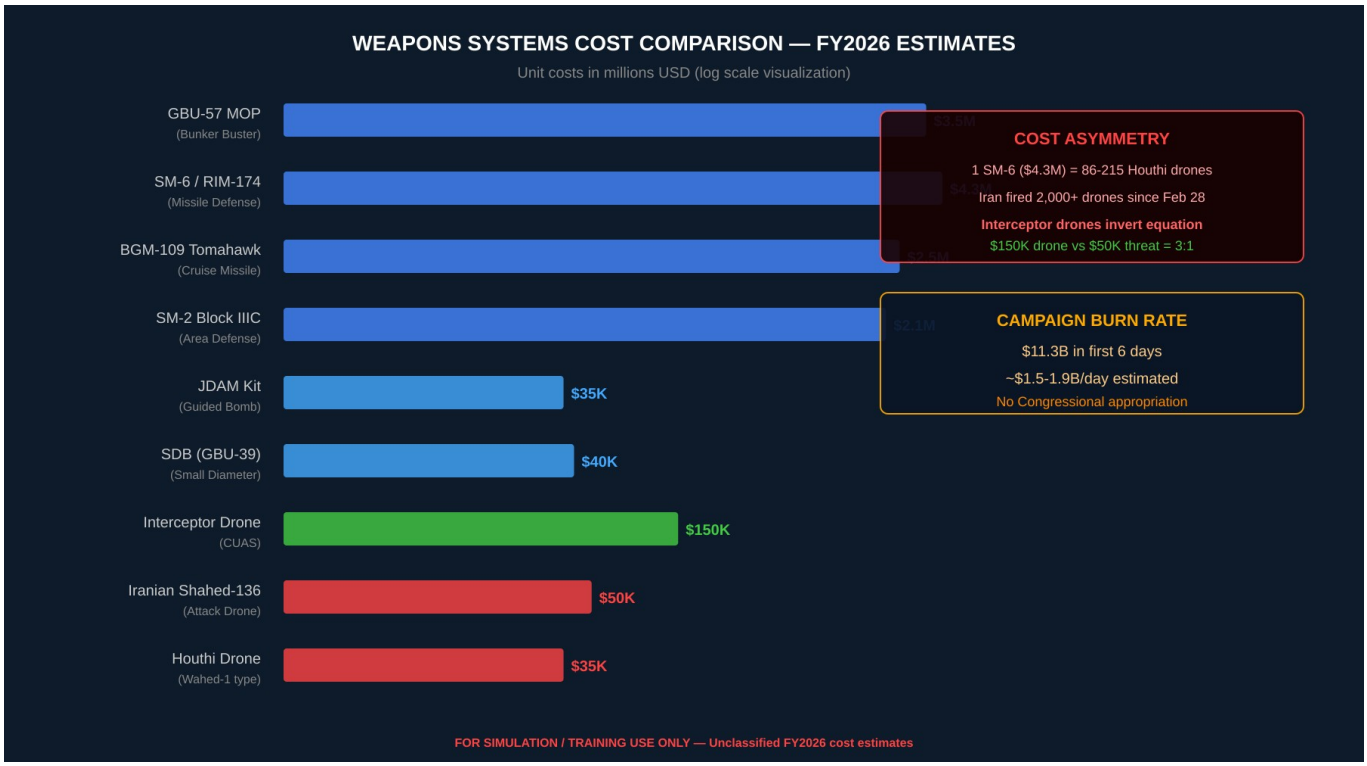
Appendix D: Weapons Systems Cost Comparison — FY2026 Estimates



Log-scale cost comparison of US offensive/defensive systems vs. Iranian/Houthi threats. Interceptor drones (green) invert the cost asymmetry.

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Appendix E: Platform Specification Cards — Set I (Strike Assets)

PLATFORM SPECIFICATION CARDS — SET I (Strike Assets)

B-2A SPIRIT
Strategic Stealth Bomber

- GBU-57 MOP delivery
- Unrefueled range: 6,000 nmi
- Payload: 40,000 lbs
- Stealth: VLO (RCS <0.1 m²)
- Crew: 2
- Active: 19 airframes

UNIT COST
$2.1B

F/A-18E/F SUPER HORNET
Carrier Strike Fighter

- JDAM, SDB, HARM
- Combat radius: 449 nmi
- 9 hardpoints, 17,750 lbs
- AN/APG-79 AESA radar
- Crew: 1-2
- Carrier-based: CVN-78, CVN-72

UNIT COST
$70.5M

BGM-109 TOMAHAWK
Cruise Missile (TLAM)

- Range: 1,550 miles
- GPS/INS + TERCOM + DSMAC
- Launched: DDG Mk-41 VLS / SSN
- Warhead: 1,000 lb conventional
- Flight: subsonic, terrain-following
- Primary standoff weapon

UNIT COST
$2.5M

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B-2A Spirit, F/A-18E/F Super Hornet, BGM-109 Tomahawk. Unit costs are unclassified FY2026 estimates.

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Appendix F: Platform Specification Cards — Set II (Defense & ISR)

PLATFORM SPECIFICATION CARDS — SET II (Defense & ISR)

SM-6 / RIM-174 ERAM
Extended Range Active Missile

- Range: 130+ nmi
- Active radar terminal guidance
- BMD + anti-ship capable
- Launched: Mk-41 VLS
- Dual-purpose: air + missile def
- Primary Hormuz escort weapon

UNIT COST
$4.3M

MQ-9 REAPER
ISR / Strike UAS

- Endurance: 27+ hours
- Payload: Hellfire, JDAM, GBU-12
- Ceiling: 50,000 ft
- Sensor: MTS-B EO/IR + SAR
- Data: Ku-band SATCOM link
- Primary Yemen ISR platform

UNIT COST
$32M

DDG-51 ARLEIGH BURKE
Guided-Missile Destroyer

- 90-96 Mk-41 VLS cells
- AN/SPY-1D(V) BMD radar
- Tomahawk + SM-6 + SM-2 + ASROC
- Speed: 30+ knots
- Crew: 323
- Hormuz escort screening force

UNIT COST
$2.1B

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SM-6/RIM-174, MQ-9 Reaper, DDG-51 Arleigh Burke. Primary assets for Hormuz escort and force protection missions.

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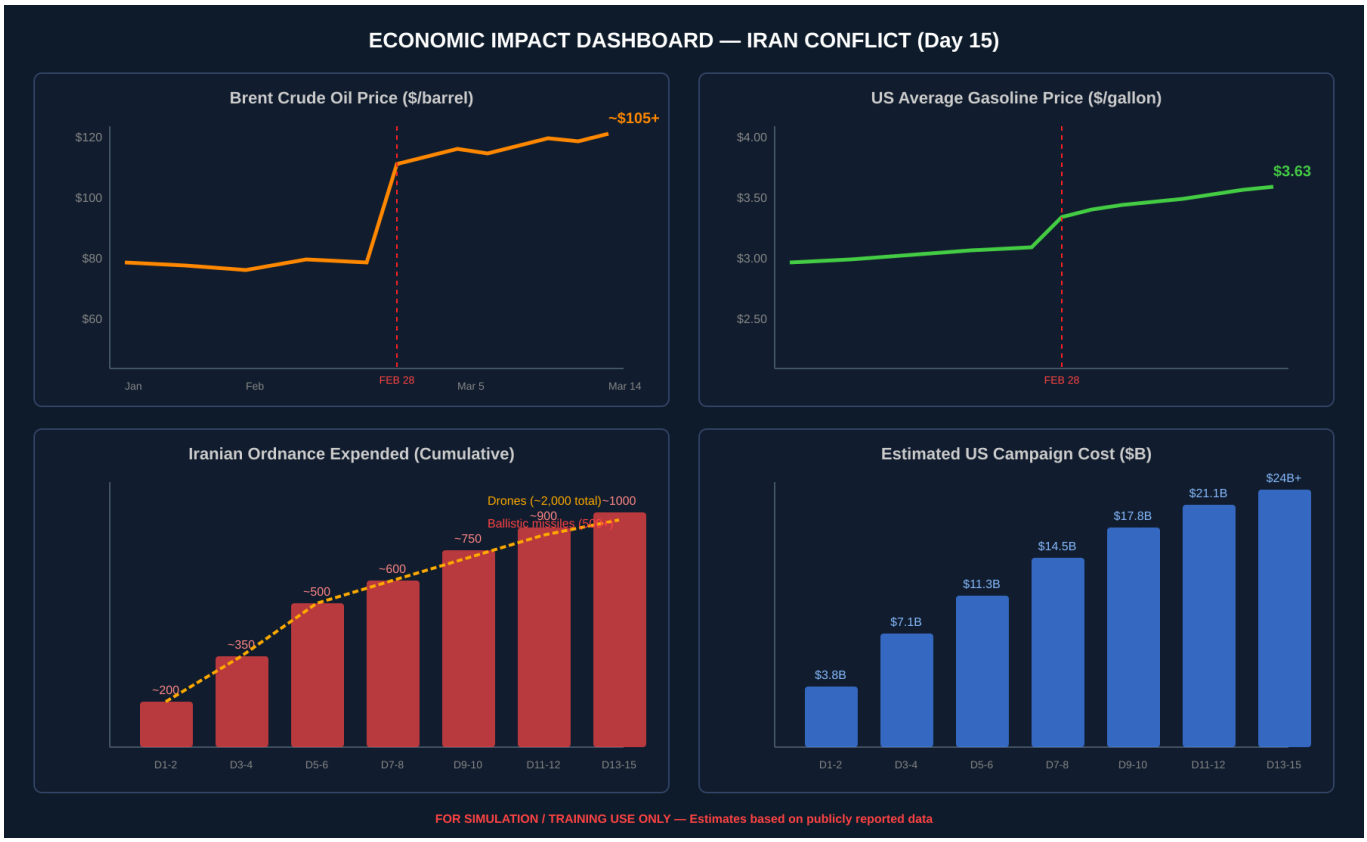
Appendix G: Economic Impact Dashboard — Iran Conflict (Day 15)



Four charts: Oil price, US gas price, Iranian ordnance expended (cumulative), estimated US campaign cost. All values approximate.

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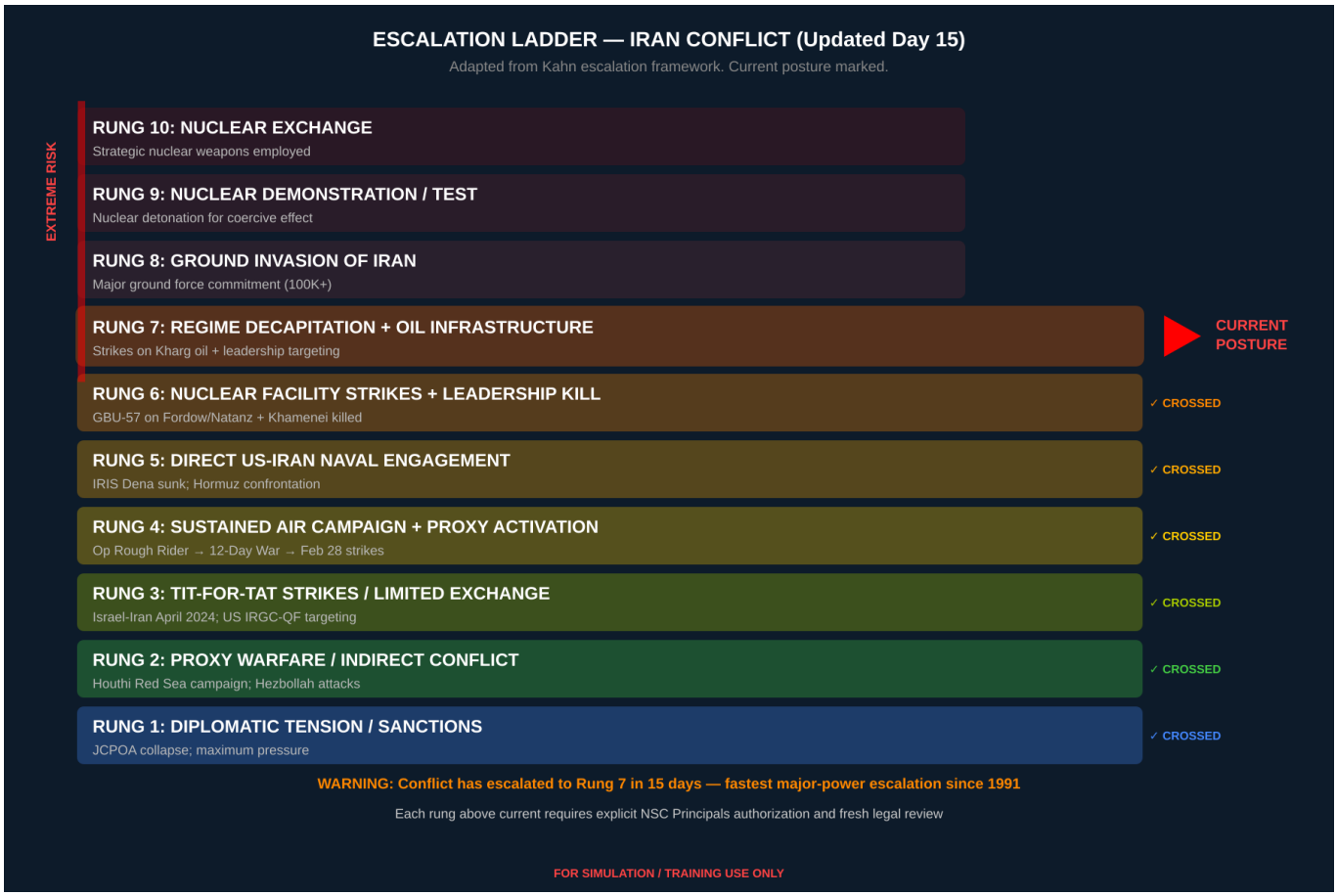
Appendix H: Escalation Ladder — Updated Day 15



Adapted from Kahn escalation framework. Current posture = Rung 7 (Regime decapitation + oil infrastructure). Rungs 1-7 crossed in 15 days.

Escalation velocity assessment: The conflict has traversed seven rungs of the Kahn escalation ladder in 15 days. For comparison, the 1990–91 Gulf War required six months of diplomatic escalation before military operations began at Rung 4. The 2003 Iraq War required approximately 18 months of political escalation. The February 28 strikes jumped directly from Rung 4 (sustained proxy warfare) to Rung 6–7 (nuclear facility strikes and regime decapitation) in a single day. This compression of the escalation timeline is unprecedented in modern great-power conflict and leaves minimal space for de-escalation signaling between rungs.

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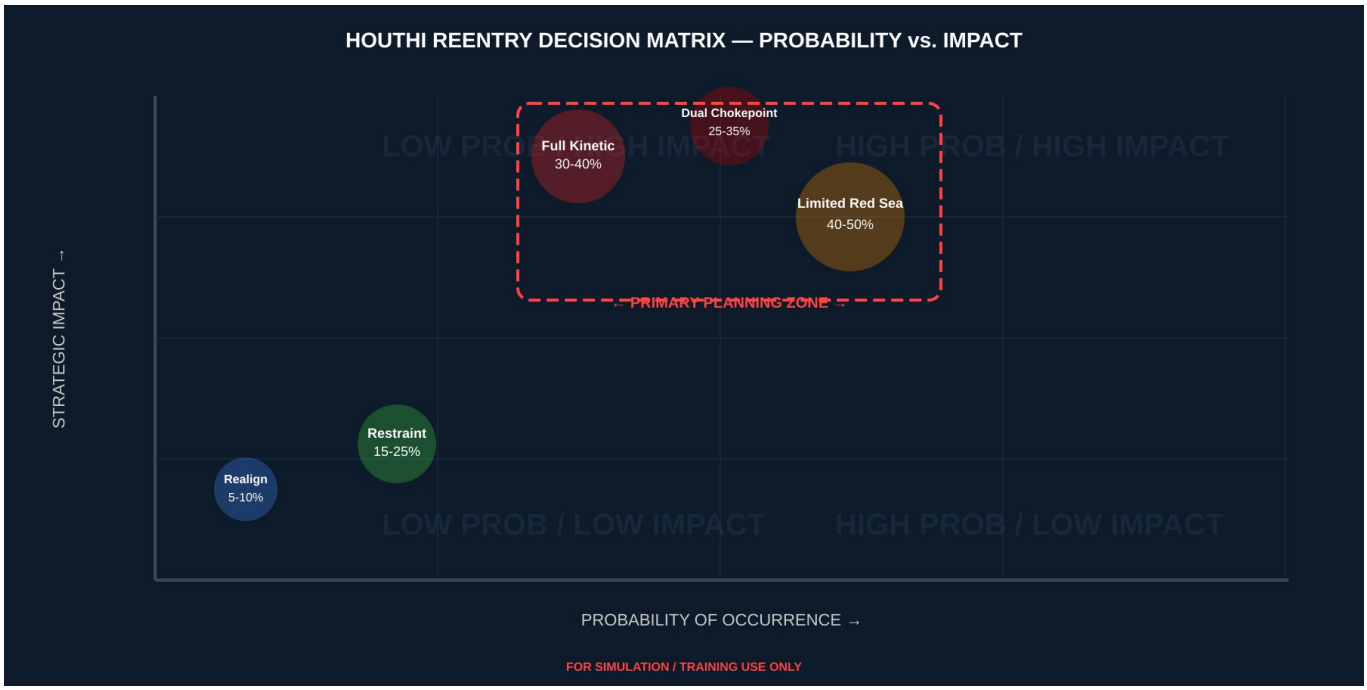
Appendix I: Houthi Reentry Decision Matrix — Probability vs. Impact



Scenario plotting by probability (x-axis) vs strategic impact (y-axis). Primary planning zone highlighted. Limited Red Sea attacks assessed as most likely.

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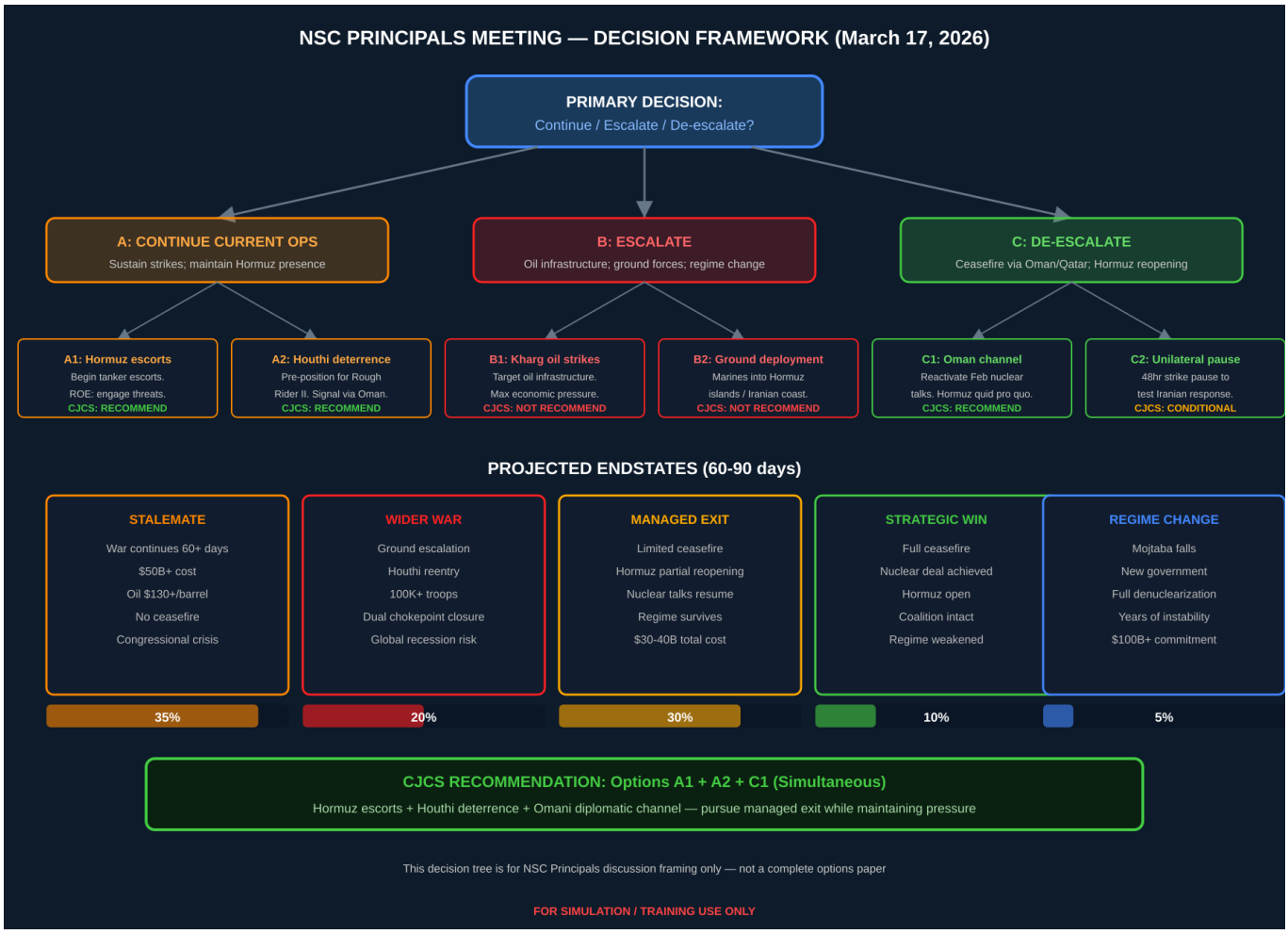
Appendix J: NSC Decision Tree — Monday Meeting Framework



Three primary branches (Continue/Escalate/De-escalate) with sub-options and endstate projections. CJCS recommends A1+A2+C1 combined.

The decision tree above represents the analytical framework the Joint Chiefs recommend for structuring Monday's discussion. The five endstate columns represent distinct strategic outcomes, each with associated probabilities, costs, and strategic implications. The CJCS recommendation (A1 + A2 + C1) — combining Hormuz escorts, Houthi deterrence, and the Omani diplomatic channel — targets the "Managed Exit" endstate (30% probability), which the Joint Chiefs assess as the most achievable favorable outcome that balances military pressure with diplomatic off-ramps.

The "Stalemate" endstate (35% probability) represents the default trajectory if the NSC takes no new decisions. The Joint Chiefs assess that stalemate is the most likely outcome absent deliberate action — which is why the recommended course of action requires affirmative decisions on all five items presented in Section XII.

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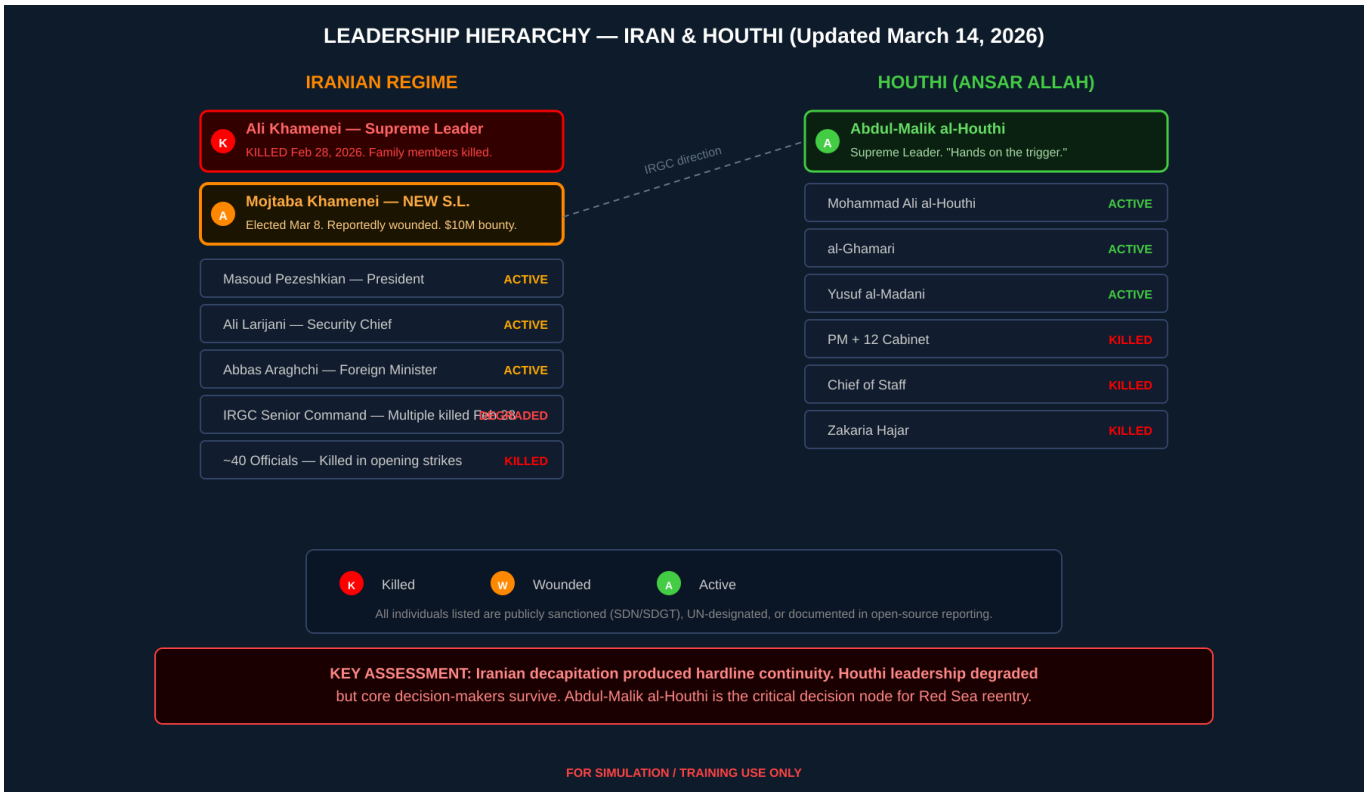
Appendix K: Leadership Hierarchy — Iran & Houthi (Updated March 14, 2026)



Status of Iranian and Houthi leadership. Green = Active; Red = Killed; Orange = Wounded. All individuals publicly sanctioned or documented.

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Appendix L: Iran/Proxy Response Probability Matrix (Updated Day 15)

IRAN / PROXY RESPONSE PROBABILITY MATRIX (Updated Day 15)

Rows = next US action. Columns = probable Iranian response. Shading = probability (darker = higher).

	Diplomatic Protest	Proxy Retaliation	Missile Salvo (Regional)	Hormuz Mine/Closure	Direct Attack on US Ships	Nuclear Breakout
Continue current strikes	5%	15%	30%	25%	15%	10%
Strike Kharg oil infra	2%	10%	25%	35%	18%	10%
Hormuz escort ops	10%	20%	25%	20%	20%	5%
Anti-Houthi strikes	15%	30%	20%	15%	10%	10%
Ground forces deploy	2%	10%	20%	25%	30%	13%
Ceasefire proposal	40%	15%	10%	15%	5%	15%

KEY: Ground forces deployment carries highest risk of direct engagement (30%). Ceasefire offers lowest.

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Analytical estimate of probable Iranian responses by US action type. Ground deployment carries highest risk of direct engagement (30%).

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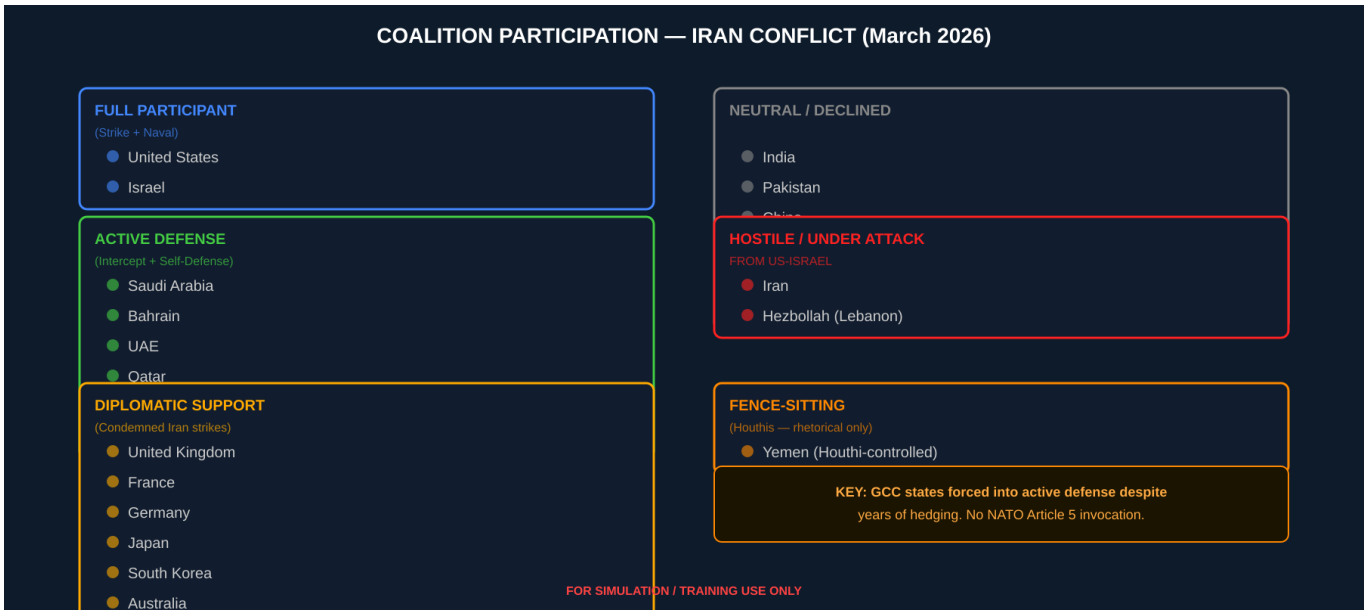
Appendix M: Coalition Participation Assessment — Iran Conflict



Participation levels mapped. GCC states forced into active defense despite years of hedging. No NATO Article 5 invocation.

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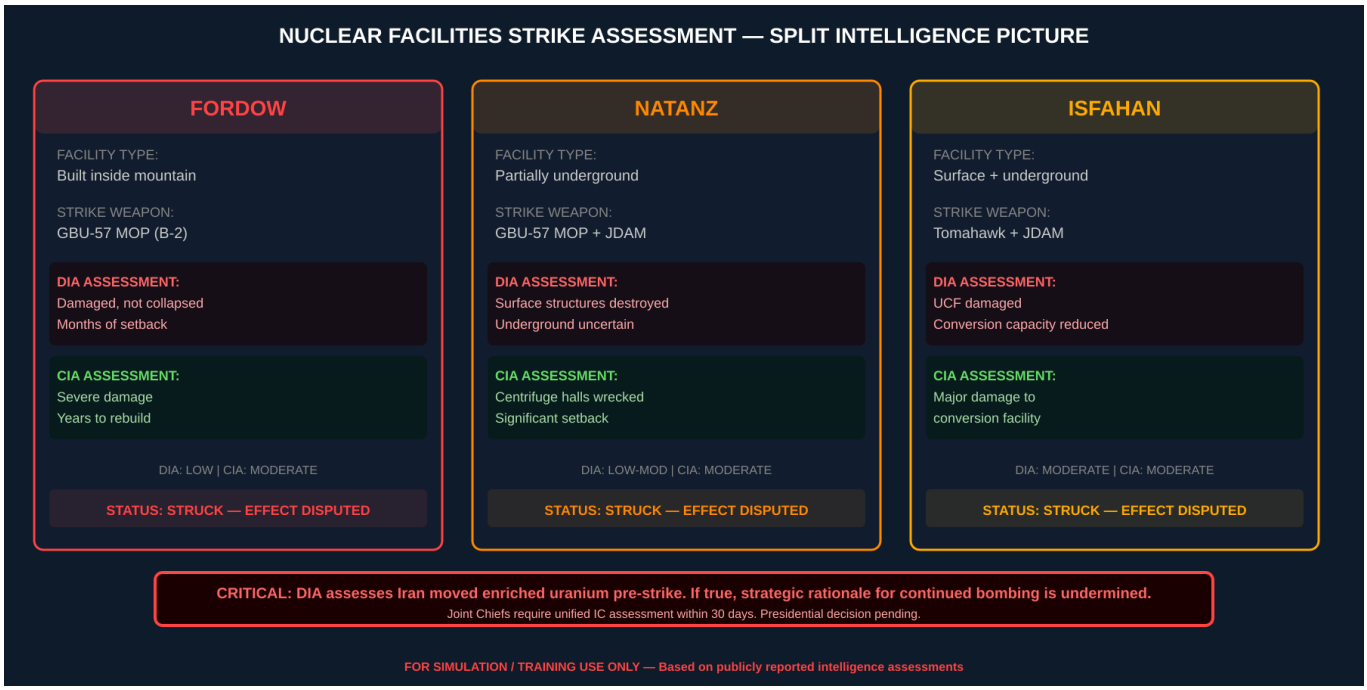
Appendix N: Nuclear Facilities Strike Assessment — Split Intelligence Picture



DIA vs CIA assessments on Fordow, Natanz, Isfahan. CRITICAL: DIA assesses Iran may have moved enriched uranium pre-strike.

The DIA/CIA intelligence split on the nuclear strike assessment is the single most important unresolved analytical question of the conflict. If the DIA assessment is correct — that Iran moved its enriched uranium stockpile before the strikes, and the underground facilities at Fordow were damaged but not collapsed — then the stated objective of neutralizing Iran's nuclear capability has not been achieved, and continued airstrikes cannot achieve it. The CIA's competing assessment that the strikes caused "severe damage" requiring "years to rebuild" supports a more favorable interpretation of the strikes' effectiveness. The Joint Chiefs require a unified assessment within 30 days. The resolution of this question fundamentally determines whether continued military operations serve the stated strategic objective.

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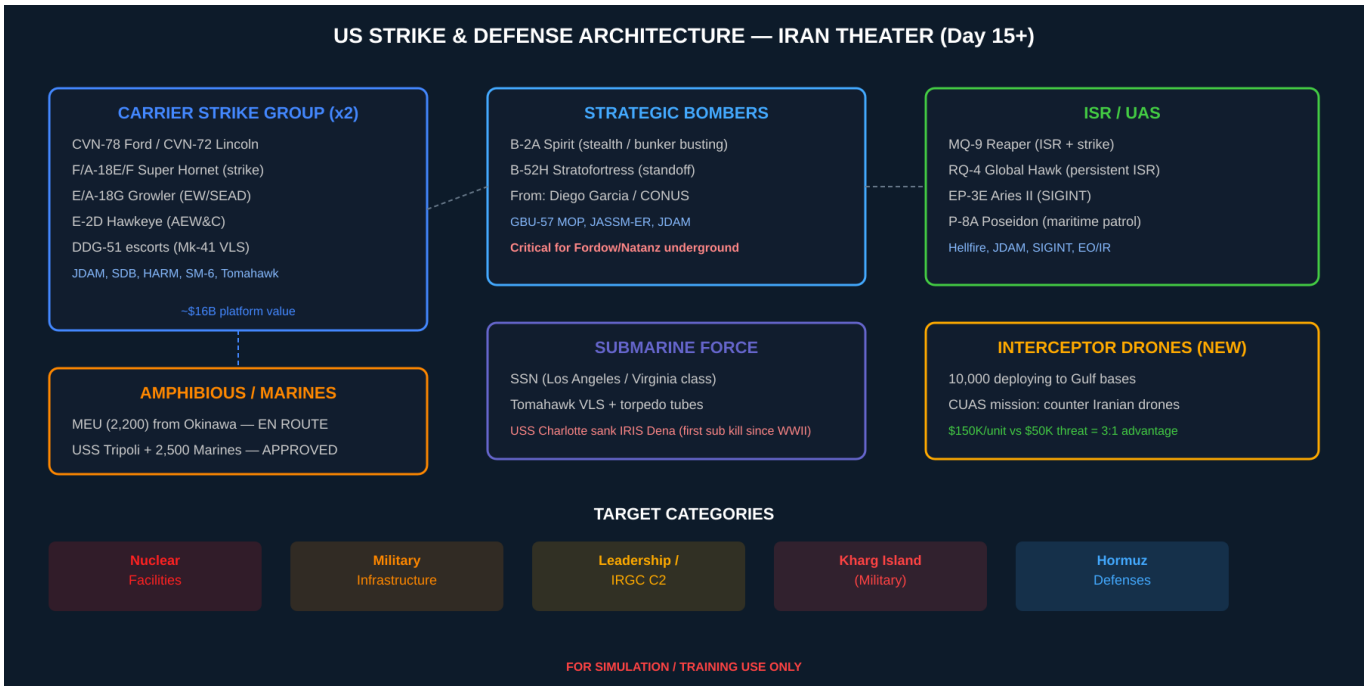
Appendix O: US Strike & Defense Architecture — Iran Theater



Schematic showing relationship between CSG, strategic bombers, ISR/UAS, submarines, interceptor drones, and amphibious forces.

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DOCUMENT NOTES & DISCLAIMERS

ACADEMIC SIMULATION EXERCISE

This memorandum was drafted with the assistance of AI (Claude Opus 4.6, Anthropic). All policy positions, strategic analysis, and recommendations reflect the views of the author and were reviewed prior to submission. AI was used for structure, drafting, formatting, analytical prediction generation, and programmatic graphic creation.

This document is a simulation exercise prepared for academic coursework on national security decision-making. It is not a U.S. government product. All predictions are analytical estimates based on open-source intelligence and publicly available information. All maps, charts, and diagrams were generated programmatically using publicly available conflict and geographic data. They are reference illustrations and not official U.S. government cartographic products.

Sources: Wikipedia (2026 Iran Conflict), Al Jazeera, CNN, Reuters, AP, ACLED, FDD Long War Journal, Atlantic Council, Stimson Center, Foreign Policy, Axios, House of Commons Library (UK), Britannica, Asharq Al-Awsat. All figures are from publicly reported data as of March 14, 2026.